Q+A

Role Play

RANDEEP HOODA, **the 48-year-old *Jaat* actor, talks about his pivot towards writing stories and new-found love for direction**



Q. You've played the antagonist a few times, including in your latest film *Jaat*. What does it really take to be an effective villain?
There is no difference with playing the hero or the villain. While I am used to doing a lot of prep for my roles, with this one, almost 90 per cent of the job is looking the part. Usually, the audience cheers for the hero but with *Jaat*, I have got so much love for Ranatunga (his character) that I am amazed.

Q. You recently said that you want to direct more...
I was an accidental director (on *Swatantrya Veer Savarkar*) but I then found that I have a flair for it. All my life, I've been co-conspiring with my directors for my part at least. What has also helped is that I've been a wildlife photographer for about eight years now, which has honed my sense of framing. I have a couple of stories that I've developed, both action films.

Q. Boman Irani, who just directed his first film, took time off to study screenplay writing and skill up. Is that something you feel you would need to do as well?
Not at all. In fact, for *Swatantrya Veer Savarkar*, I also co-wrote the screenplay with Utkarsh Naithani and it just flew out of me. I didn't feel the need to get any other skill set at all. Maybe I was just born to do it (laughs).

Q. Do you enjoy writing?
I really do. Since the screenplay, I've been writing short stories in Hindi. They basically document our times. I write about Versova (a suburb in Mumbai) and the characters I have known. When you read a lot, you also want to write because your thoughts need an outlet. I did most of my writing after I broke my knee while horse riding. I have about 10-15 short stories written. A few more and I'll probably put them out there as a book.

—with Karishma Upadhyay